

Digilians

Freelancing MODULE

NEGOTIATION SKILLS FOR FREELANCERS

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Participant's Manual



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Module 1: Understanding Negotiation

What is Negotiation?

Negotiation is a communication process where two or more parties aim to reach an agreement. It is not a competition, but rather a dialogue focused on understanding, compromise, and achieving win-win results.

Why Negotiation is Essential for Freelancers

Aspect	Traditional Jobs	Freelancing
Representation	HR personnel or manager	You represent yourself
Client/Employer Communication	Usually indirect	Direct with the client
Flexibility of Terms	Fixed in a formal contract	Flexible (you can accept, reject, or modify)
Pricing	Predefined by the company	You set the price based on value and project
Task Assignment	Fixed and assigned by management	Negotiable per client and project
Negotiation on Revisions	Rare – based on company policy	Common – requires a clear agreement
Client Choice	None – you're bound to the company	Full – you choose whom you work with

Freelancers negotiate daily — with clients, partners, and vendors.

It impacts how much they earn, how clients perceive them, and how sustainable their workflow becomes.

Strong negotiation skills lead to better rates, clearer expectations, and long-term collaborations.

Common Mistakes Freelancers Make When Negotiating

Saying yes too quickly to avoid losing the project.

Being afraid to ask for more money or better terms.

Thinking negotiation is only about price.

Not documenting agreements in writing.

Overpromising to win clients.

Taking feedback or rejection personally.

Module 2: Negotiation Strategies (Lewicki & Hiam's Matrix)

The Negotiation Matrix

Lewicki and Hiam's matrix outlines five core negotiation strategies depending on the situation and your goals.



Source: Thomas-Kilmann Instrument

1. Competing – Prioritize your goal over the relationship. Focused on winning.
2. Accommodating – Prioritize the relationship over your own goals. Builds trust.
3. Avoiding – Choose not to engage, often to de-escalate emotional situations.
4. Compromising – Both sides make concessions to find balance.
5. Collaborating – Aim for a win-win solution, best for partnerships.

When to Use Each Strategy

Strategy	Use When	Outcome
Competing	High-stakes, urgent situations	Quick decisions
Accommodating	Relationship matters more than small gain	Trust building
Avoiding	Issue is minor or emotions are high	Temporary calm
Compromising	Both need a balanced solution	Fair middle ground
Collaborating	Both seek mutual success	Long-term partnership

Activity: Choose Your Strategy

Think of three client negotiation examples. For each, choose which strategy you would use and why.

Module 3: How to Negotiate Without Undervaluing Yourself

The TRIP Model for Freelancers

Use the TRIP framework to assess negotiation elements objectively.

T – Timeline: Can the deadline be adjusted?

R – Rate: Is the budget flexible?

I – Inclusions: What's included in the scope?

P – Payment Terms: Is payment upfront, partial, or upon completion?

Golden Rule

Never reduce your price without changing the project scope, inclusions, or delivery timeline.

Example Scenario

✓ Sample Reshaped Offer (TRIP Applied)

"Thanks for sharing the request! A full e-commerce site with multilingual support and admin dashboard typically takes 3–4 weeks and a much higher budget.
Let me propose a realistic version of what we can do for now:"

🔄 Adjusted Offer Using TRIP:

Element	Adjusted Offer	📄
Timeline	Extended to 15 business days	
Rate	Adjusted to \$600	
Inclusions	Basic e-commerce homepage + product listing page + checkout flow (1 language, no dashboard)	
Payment	50% upfront, 50% on final testing.	

Client: 'We need a 5-page website for \$150.'

Freelancer: 'For that budget, I can create a simplified landing page with fewer features. If you'd like the full 5-page website, I can send you a detailed quote.'

Dealing with Difficult Clients

Client Type	Behavior	Response
Perfectionist	Never satisfied	Set clear revision limits and scope.
Defensive	Takes feedback personally	Use calm, factual language.
Aggressive	Pushes for discounts	Be firm and refer to your rate sheet.
Complaining	Finds faults frequently	Request specific examples and document everything.
Arrogant	Undermines your expertise	Stay polite and keep communication professional.

Activity: Practice the TRIP Model

Rewrite this message using TRIP:

'Can you deliver this by tomorrow for \$50?' Clarify your timeline, rate, inclusions, and payment expectations.

Module 4: Setting Boundaries with Confidence

Why Boundaries Matter

Boundaries protect your time, mental health, and energy. They help maintain balance and professional respect.

Common Boundary Crossings

Situation	Description	Risk Level	Example	
 Unlimited Edits	Client keeps asking for "just one more" change after each delivery	HIGH	"We're 9 rounds in — the project should've been finished."	
 Urgent WhatsApp at 2 AM	Client believes you're available 24/7 once you're hired	HIGH	"Please send the final version tonight or I'll cancel."	
 More Work After Payment	Client wants "a few more things" after you've delivered and been paid	MEDIUM	"Can you also add an English version? You already got paid."	
 Changing Scope Midway	Brief changes, but the budget doesn't	HIGH	"We actually want a full website now, not just a landing page."	

Unlimited revisions requests.

Scope creep ('Just one more page...').

Late-night messages or urgent tasks with no notice.

Clients requesting unpaid work.

How to Set Boundaries Professionally

Define a clear revision policy (e.g., 'Includes 2 revisions, extra costs apply afterward').

Share a rate sheet with detailed services and prices.

Set work hours and communicate availability clearly.

Document scope and deliverables in writing.

Tips for Maintaining Boundaries

Be polite but firm when communicating your limits.

Repeat boundaries consistently — don't bend under pressure.

Never apologize for professional policies.

Respect your own time — others will too.

Activity: Define Your Work Policy

Create a personal 'Freelancer Work Policy' that lists your working hours, revision policy, communication expectations, and payment terms.

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